

The application is ultra slim and ad-free, and is designed to play all QuickTime media files, including MOV, QT, and 3GP files (the formats that most mobile phone clips are saved in) as well as streamed multimedia content and QuickTime content embedded in Web pages. The plug-in codecs for the latest versions of Internet Explorer, Netscape, Firefox, Opera and Mozilla, which are integrated into the player, serve this purpose well. For streaming video, you can also enable the Instant-On feature, which starts playing the video as soon as it starts loading. At lower Internet speeds, though, this results in frequent pauses during playback and reduces the quality of playback.

When paired with the Real Alternative player, you can play back almost any video file on your computer as the two together support nearly every major multimedia format. This includes MP3, MPEG, AVI, CD/DVD content, Windows Media (.wmv), RealAudio (.ra and .rpm), and RealMedia (.rm, .ram, .smil, and more) files.

The QuickTime Alternative installed without any trouble. A point to note here is that if you have another QuickTime version installed on your computer, you would have to uninstall it before installing QuickTime Alternative. This, of course, we did without hesitation.

Files loaded and played without delay, and playback was smooth. Even though the application is free, it offers all the necessary options and functions. These include the ability to bookmark favourite files, adjust volume in the window, track file progress, load subtitles, etc. The Options menu is loaded enough to give a novice cold feet. The player looks and feels like any regular bare-bones media player, but with its robust back-end and wide-ranging support, you'd not need to look elsewhere for video playback. If we had to ask for anything more it would be skin support: the Windows Classic look does get a little boring.

4.2.3 RealPlayer Alternative

Something of an "Attack of the Alternatives" you'd say, considering this back-to-back review of two alternative applications to two wide-